

What else to watch: *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968, pp.192–93) ■ *The Color of Pomegranates* (1969) ■ *Solaris* (1972) ■ *Werckmeister Harmonies* (2000)

“When a man thinks of the past, he becomes kinder.”

The Stalker / Stalker

Stalker, like many of Tarkovsky's other movies, was adapted from an existing work, in this case, the 1971 novel *Roadside Picnic* by Arkady and Boris Strugatsky, which describes the aftermath of a series of extraterrestrial incursions, called the Visitation, at six zones around the globe.

The casual detritus left behind by the unseen Visitors is compared in the book to “the usual mess” left at a picnic: “apple cores, candy wrappers, charred remains of the campfire, cans, bottles, somebody's handkerchief, somebody's penknife, torn newspapers, coins, faded flowers picked in another meadow.” Just as a picnic's detritus baffles—and threatens—the animals that find it, so too are humans perplexed

by the strange phenomena that they stumble across after the Visitors have left.

The unexplained

Unusually for science fiction of the time, the actual Visitation itself was of no concern in the novel; nor is it for Tarkovsky. His interest in the science-fiction genre resulted in another masterpiece, *Solaris*, but he used the form to suit his own artistic ends. Indeed, *Stalker's* slow opening does not even try to explain what has given rise to the »

The “Writer” (Anatoly Solonitsyn) places a crown of thorns on his head as the men wait in the telephone room while in The Zone. Like many images in the movie, the allusion is obscure.



Andrei Tarkovsky
Director

Born in 1932 to a family of poets and writers in the Soviet town of Zavrazhnye, Andrei Tarkovsky decided upon a career in movie in his early twenties. Enrolling to study direction at Moscow's State Institute Of Cinematography, where Sergei Eisenstein was also taught, he made his first student short film in 1956: *The Killers*, adapted from a short story by Ernest Hemingway. Tarkovsky's first feature, *Ivan's Childhood*, launched a high-profile career of stylish and nuanced art-house movies. After a slow start—just two full-length features in the 1960s, including the acclaimed *Andrei Rublev*—he made up for lost time in the 1970s, beginning with the space story *Solaris*. Characterized by long takes and mysterious symbolism, his movies pose deep existential questions about life and its meaning. He died in Paris in 1986.

Key movies

1962 *Ivan's Childhood*
1966 *Andrei Rublev*
1972 *Solaris*
1979 *Stalker*

